

The Study of Human Sexuality

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Sexual Literacy

Sexual literacy — the knowledge, skills, and actions needed to promote and protect sexual well-being.

Sexual well-being — the condition of experiencing good health, pleasure, and satisfaction in intimate relationships.

Holistic sexuality — the integration of body, mind, feelings, and social life through your sexuality.

Figure 1.1 Sexual literacy



Becoming Sexually Literate

Models of Doug Kerby (2012) and Miriam Arbeit (2014)

Three components defined by Arbeit:

- **Sexual selfhood** — the totality of oneself as a sexual being, including positive and negative feelings.
- **Sexual negotiation** — discussion and interaction that lead to agreement about sexual relationships.
- **Sexual empowerment** — taking responsibility for one's own sexuality, making one's own choices, and respecting one's own needs, desires, and values.

**Why do we need to
know about Sexuality?**

Important Sexual Literacy Goals for this Course

- Understand yourself as a whole person
- Communicate emotional and intimate sexual needs
- Understand others by first learning about your own body, desires, and behaviors, and how you might express them
- Learn what science and research tell us about sexuality, and how to separate facts from myths

Important Sexual Literacy Goals for this Course

- Understand how contexts shapes sexuality
 - Both in nature and culture
- Be able to discuss your own culture's sexual attitudes and how they contribute to your own holistic well-being.
- Have the knowledge and skills to protect your sexual health throughout life.
- Be able to implement the decisions and actions to protect your sexual well-being when you need and want to.

Sexual Well-Being

Fundamental four elements to achieve sexual well-being:

1. *Pleasure*—involving acceptance of yourself, your body, and the role of pleasure in your own development.
2. *Protection*—keeping your body free of sexually transmitted infections and other conditions; and knowing how to deal with sexual coercion.
3. *Focus*—being present and fully aware of your sexually feelings, your partner, and to situations.
4. *Purpose in life*—strengthening your sense of identity and validating your existence, including within relationships.

Sexual Science—A Historical Perspective

Sexual science — the study of sexual behavior across the human species, all cultures, and individuals.

Sexology — systematic study of sexual interests, functions, and behaviors.

Today, positive aspects of sexuality include:

- Sexual health and wellness;
- Social and cultural influences; and
- The relationship between marriage and sexual intimacy.

The Medical Model of Sexuality

Early studies of sexuality were led by psychiatrists and medical doctors

- Focused on sex acts as negative or abnormal
- **Sexual degeneracy** — impairment or decline of sexual function.
- Masturbation was considered a serious sexual disease.
- Attitudes were often biased against women and children.
- Some doctors were prudish, ignorant, and focused on highly religious theories.

A New Approach to Sex Research

Richard von Krafft-Ebing

- Coined the term **fetishism** — attraction to physical objects
- Classified “abnormal” sexual symptoms as **perversions** — sexual urges or acts considered unusual or extreme in a specific culture

A New Approach to Sex Research

Magnus Hirschfeld

- First to use surveys to study sexual behavior in groups of people

A New Approach to Sex Research

Havelock Ellis

- One of the leading authorities in the treatment of sexual problems.
- Clinical studies of individual patients
 - Remain fascinating due to their meticulous observations and objectivity

A New Approach to Sex Research

Sigmund Freud

- Believed people's earliest desires and fantasies centered on conflicted sexual attraction to the opposite-sex parent.
- Developed **psychoanalysis**, also known as talking therapy, to uncover feelings and memories hidden in the unconscious mind.
- **Repress** — to suppress upsetting sexual feelings or memories to prevent mental distress or unacceptable behavior.
- **Biological bisexuality** — the idea that people may be naturally attracted to both sexes.
- **Erogenous zones** — major areas of the body that are highly sensitive to sexual stimulation.

A New Approach to Sex Research

Bronislaw Malinowski

- Invented **participant-observation** — a research method in which the researcher observes behavior outside a clinical setting, within its natural cultural and linguistic context

A New Approach to Sex Research

Margaret Mead

- Demonstrated that culture shapes sexual behavior in teenagers more than personality or biology
- Showed that cultures vary widely in gender roles and adult sexual expression

Sex Research Comes of Age

Alfred Kinsey

- Applied scientific methodology to eliminate superstition and harmful stereotypes.
- Pioneered **survey study** to examine different kinds of sexuality.
- **Representative samples** — components of the population that represent diverse segments of the population of interest.

Sex Research Comes of Age

Mary Calderone

- First female doctor to promote contraceptives and adopt a more positive view of human sexuality

Sex Research Comes of Age

William Masters and Virginia Johnson

- Worked together to understand how people became aroused and what went wrong when they couldn't have an orgasm.
- Observed sexual behavior in the laboratory.
- Developed a technique to deal with **sexual dysfunction** — the inability to enjoy sexual intercourse or achieve orgasm.
- Discovered that women generally could have multiple orgasms.
- **Refractory period** — the normal response immediately after ejaculation, when men cannot ejaculate.

Sex and Social Justice Today

When applied correctly, sex research can

- Lower rates of sexually transmitted infections (STIs);
- Lower rates of unintended pregnancy;
- Better mental and physical health correlates of sexual behavior; and
- Generally a higher level of sexual well-being.

However, in the United States, a “code of silence” surrounds sexual health and sex education.

Ethics of Sexual Research

Protecting research participants

- Ensure that data collection is done anonymously and confidentially
- Ensure that participants are of legal age
- Verify that participants' attitudes, experiences, and behaviors are accurately reported regarding age, ethnicity, and gender
- Ensure that no harm comes to research participants

Human Sexual Rights

Universal human rights — freedoms to which all humans are entitled.

Human sexuality rights include these

- The right to equality and nondiscrimination;
- The right to teach and learn about sex;
- The right to respect people's bodies;
- The right to be sexually active or not;
- The right to choose when and how to have children or not;
- The right to pursue sexual pleasure in a safe and satisfying way.

Questions?